

AYESHA ZAFAR

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EDUCATION

University of California, Berkeley; Goldman School of Public Policy

Berkeley, CA

Master of Public Policy

Expected Graduation May 2026

- GPA: 3.97 / 4.00

- *Coursework:* International Poverty and Economic Development, Policy Analysis and Professional Practice, Data Science, Behavioral Science, Comparative Politics, Critical Systems of Development, GIS and Public Policy

Graduate Certificates:

- Graduate Certificate in Geographic Information Science and Technology (GIST) May 2026
- Graduate Certificate in Applied Data Science December 2026

University of Manchester; Global Development Institute

Manchester, UK

Master of Science in International Development

Graduated December 2022

- *Concentration:* Politics, Governance and Development Policy
- *Coursework:* Planning and Managing Development, Development Fundamentals, Development Fieldwork, Politics and Governance of Development, Gender Inequality, Conflict Analysis, Understanding Development Research, Political Analysis of Development Policy.

National University of Sciences and Technology, School of Social Sciences

Islamabad, PK

Bachelor of Science in Economics

Graduated July 2021

- *Coursework:* Macroeconomics I, II and III, Microeconomics I, II, and III, Econometrics I, II, and III, Mathematical Economics I and II, Intro to Statistics, Monetary Policy, Public Policy, Development Economics, Behavioural and Experimental Economics, Population Economics, International Trade, Game Theory.

PROJECTS

MPP Capstone

University of California, Berkeley; AAPI Force

January 2026 – Current

- Collecting, integrating, and analyzing administrative and case-level data to quantify detentions and deportations of Southeast Asian individuals from Laos, Cambodia, and Vietnam since January 2025.
- Estimating populations at risk of future detention or removal and assessing potential avenues for relief to inform community advocacy and policy strategy.
- Authoring a final capstone report, synthesizing administrative and case-level data analysis with legal and policy frameworks to generate evidence-based estimates, risk projections, and policy recommendations for advocacy and strategic decision-making.

Policy Advocacy Clinic: Homelessness Research

University of California, Berkeley; Western Regional Advocacy Project

September 2025 – December 2025

- Evaluated the potential impact of the bill H.R. 1 on homelessness through extensive evaluation and impact assessment of historical policies.
- Examined 2000s-era federal housing and homelessness policy responses-including the subprime housing crisis and the HEARTH Act-to assess how shifts in housing affordability, foreclosure, and federal homelessness frameworks shaped contemporary homelessness trends.
- Co-authored a policy report synthesizing findings and presented recommendations to key stakeholders.

Independent Study: Theory of Culture

University of California, Berkeley

January 2025 – June 2025

- Built a cross-country, multi-year panel (156 countries, 1998–2021, 26 indicators), harmonised codes/years, imputed/flagged missingness, and scripted a fully reproducible R workflow.
- Estimated links between incentives and cultural-economic outcomes using fixed effects and robust regressions, with clustered SEs, interaction terms, and sensitivity checks; produced publication-ready figures and a documented analysis pipeline.

Graduate Student Consultant: Evaluation Framework for Education in Somaliland

University of California, Berkeley

January 2025 – June 2025

- Collaborated with a team of four policy analysts to design an evaluation framework for Kaabe Schools, benchmarking student performance, retention, and gender disparity against international standards; produced policy recommendations to strengthen teacher training and curriculum.

- Co-authored the final report translating evaluation findings into policy recommendations to strengthen teacher training and curriculum design.

Graduate Thesis: The Role of Media in Exacerbating Gender Inequality in Pakistan January 2022 – October 2022
University of Manchester

- A thematic discourse analysis of gender representations in popular Pakistani TV drama and discourse analysis on the audience's reaction to those gender representations. Earned a Merit on the final report.

Field Research Project: Evaluating Women's Political Participation in Uganda January 2022 – June 2022
University of Manchester

- Collaborated with a multidisciplinary team to conduct in-depth interviews with diverse stakeholders, including public officials, educators, and representatives from civil society organizations, to gather qualitative insights on gender dynamics in political participation and Uganda's education sector.
- Authored a fieldwork-based analytical research essay applying critical mass theory to interview evidence and secondary literature to examine institutional, socio-cultural, and political constraints on women's effective political participation; the paper earned a Distinction.

Undergraduate Thesis: Gender Disparity and its Impact on the Pakistani Economy January 2021 - July 2021
National University of Sciences and Technology

- Using the ARDL model, the research paper determines the long-run relationship between gender disparity in education and real macroeconomic variables of the Pakistani economy, aiming to determine policy implications of reducing gender disparity. Earned a B+ (3.5 GPA) on the final report.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

University of California, Berkeley Berkeley, USA
Graduate Student Instructor January 2025 – Current

- *Course:* Intro to Comparative Politics (Spring 2025) and Global Poverty (Fall 2025; Spring 2026)
- Responsible to provide support to at least 54 students each term.
- Facilitated weekly discussion sections, held office hours, and graded assignments, providing academic support and fostering student engagement with the political, economic, and ethical dimensions of global poverty and development policy.

World Wildlife Fund Washington DC, USA
WILDLABS Intern June 2025 – September 2025

- Leveraged R to execute quantitative analysis of five years of global conservation technology survey data, including data cleaning, recoding, and longitudinal visualizations across eleven conservation technologies, making survey data reproducible and policy relevant.
- Conducted qualitative analysis in NVivo, systematically coding open-text responses to surface trends in user experiences, adoption challenges, and capacity needs across the conservation tech sector.
- Interviewed WWF President & CEO Carter Roberts, synthesizing insights on conservation leadership and global environmental strategy.
- Co-authored and contributed to the State of Conservation Technology Report, published on the WILDLABS website, informing funders and practitioners on global tech adoption trends.

Caterpillar Dubai, UAE
EAME Graduate Trainee July 2022 – June 2023

- Leveraged Python, Power Automate, and Power BI to build six automations, four Power BI dashboards, and 16 data analytics reports, significantly enhancing data-driven decision-making and improving operational efficiency.
- Produced monthly data analytics reports on the Middle East and Eurasia Results for Senior leadership, providing critical insights into regional performance and supporting evidence-based policy adjustments for strategic growth.
- Conducted capacity and capability analyses for four priority dealers using insights from consultants, sales data, facility data, and technician data, enabling resource allocation and capability development that aligned with organizational objectives.
- As a member of the Women Initiative Network, helped organize a panel with women leaders and designed a series of workshops focused on providing women with technical skills, promoting gender equity, and empowering women to succeed in technical fields.

CORE COMPETENCIES

Quantitative Analysis: Microsoft Excel, STATA, R, Power Automate, Python

Data Visualisation: ArcGIS Pro, Power BI, Microsoft PowerPoint

Language: Fluent in English and Urdu